came into her own with *Raazi* [2018], in which she plays an Indian spy. The film grossed Rs 122 crore. In *Gully Boy* [2019], Alia needed all of eight scenes to leave a lasting impression as a feisty girlfriend to Ranveer Singh's aspiring rapper from the slums. The film earned Rs 134 crore. Among her contemporaries, Deepika Padukone is the only one who comes close to her sustained success.

But throw these numbers at her, and Alia shrugs them off. She is 'Paul the Octopus', as Zoya Akhtar calls her, whose instinct for scripts rarely goes wrong. "What one needed to do, one has done," says Alia. "After that, you sit back, and wait for the results." And those results have largely been positive, a privilege few female actors of her generation can boast of.

THE METHOD BEHIND THE GENIUS

Ask the directors who have collaborated with her, and they commend the effort Alia puts into bringing her characters alive. For *Gangubai...*, which is likely to fetch her more trophy ware early next year, Bhansali didn't want Alia to visit Kamatipura, Mumbai's red light neighbourhood. He wanted her to walk into it, much like Ganga, the aspiring actor, had in the '50s. For homework, Alia watched *Pakeezah*, *Mandi*, *Memoirs of a Geisha* and *Born into Brothels*, Zana Briski

ON KARAN JOHAR

"There are few people you naturally feel comfortable with and he is one of them. He will always be my mentor. He has gone on to play many roles in my life—of a father and a friend. I go to him for advice on my professional and personal life. At his core, he is made up of a lot of goodness. He will always guide me in the right direction"



GETTY IMAGES

On a Role

Alia's other noteworthy performances



Student of the Year (2012)

In this college romance, Bhatt proves that she is more than capable of being a mainstream heroine

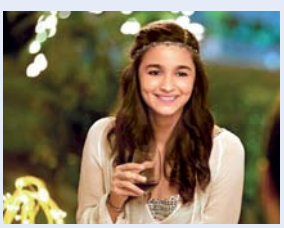


Highway (2014)

The Imtiaz Ali-directed drama was the first film to highlight Alia's thespian skills. She was 20 and this was only her second film

Kapoor & Sons (2016)

Bhatt plays a small but significant part in Shakun Batra's detailed portrait of a family





Udta Punjab (2016)

Shahid Kapoor convinced a skeptical Abhishek Chaubey to cast Alia as a migrant worker trapped in Punjab's drug crisis. Alia stole the show

Dear Zindagi (2016)

Alia essayed the emotional vulnerabilities of a millennial woman seeking therapy

